IN THE UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
FOR THE DISTRICT OF NEW HAMPSHIRE

MARILYN C. JONAS
and
GORDON-DARBY HOLDINGS, INC.,
Plaintiffs,
v.
KELLY AYOTTE, IN HER OFFICIAL CAPACITY AS THE GOVERNOR OF THE STATE OF NEW HAMPSHIRE, et al.,
Defendants.

Civil No. 26-cv-600-LM-TSM

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Defendants.

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MOTION TO DISMISS AS TO GOVERNOR AYOTTE, THE EXECUTIVE COUNCIL, AND EXECUTIVE COUNCILORS KENNEY, LIOT HILL, STEPHENS, STEPHEN, AND WHEELER WITH ACCOMPANYING MEMORANDUM OF LAW

NOW COME Defendants, Kelly Ayotte, in her official capacity as the Governor of the State of New Hampshire, the Executive Council of the State of New Hampshire, and its respective members in their official capacities, District 1 Executive Councilor Joseph D. Kenney, District 2 Executive Councilor Karen Liot Hill, District 3 Executive Councilor Janet Stevens, District 4 Executive Councilor John Stephen, and District 5 Executive Councilor David K. Wheeler (together the "Governor and Council Defendants"), and submit this Motion to Dismiss Plaintiffs' complaint pursuant to Fed. R. Civ. Proc. 12(b)(1) and 12(b)(6) and accompanying memorandum of law.

INTRODUCTION

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2025 N.H. Laws Ch. 141, §§244-256 ("HB2") eliminated the State's vehicle emissions and inspection and maintenance ("I/M") program contained in the State's current federally approved and effective Clean Air Act ("CAA") State Implementation Plan ("SIP") and repealed the respective New Hampshire Department of Safety ("NHDOS") and New Hampshire Department of Environmental Services ("NHDES") statutory authorities to implement and enforce the I/M program effective January 31, 2026. A NHDES petition to remove the I/M program from the SIP as unnecessary based on air quality improvements was submitted to the Environmental Protection Agency ("EPA") on December 24, 2025 and remains pending.[1] Plaintiffs Marilyn C. Jonas ("Jonas") and Gordon-Darby Holdings, Inc. ("Gordon-Darby"), filed this action on July 22, 2026, seeking relief under the CAA citizen suit provisions and Federal Declaratory Judgment Act to "compel New Hampshire state officials to comply with" the CAA. ECF-1 at 3. Plaintiffs also seek a declaratory judgment that HB2 conflicts with the State's EPA-approved SIP and is therefore preempted under the Supremacy Clause and also that Defendants are in violation of emission standards or limitations within the meaning of 42 U.S.C. §7604(a)(1) and (f), together with an award of their costs, including attorney and expert witness fees, and the imposition of civil penalties pursuant to 42 U.S.C. §7604(a). For the reasons set forth herein, Plaintiffs' claims against the Governor and Council Defendants should be dismissed pursuant to Fed. R. Civ. P. 12(b)(1) for lack of standing and as barred under the Eleventh Amendment, and 12(b)(6) for failure to state a claim upon which relief can be granted in a citizen suit.

BACKGROUND

This Court's familiarity with the background of this matter, and prior and related proceedings, is assumed. *See Gordon-Darby Holdings, Inc. v. NH Dep't of Safety*, 817 F. Supp.

[1] On August 11, 2026, EPA issued a notice of proposed rulemaking proposing to conditionally approve the State's SIP amendment and to remove New Hampshire from the so-called Ozone Transport Region. 91 Fed. Reg. 51644 (Aug. 11, 2026) ("Proposed OTR Removal"); 91 Fed. Reg. 51640 (Aug. 11, 2026) ("Proposed SIP Revision"). The public comment period on the proposed rulemaking is open through September 25, 2026.

3d 82, 90 (D. N.H. 2026), *Gordon-Darby Holdings, Inc. v. NH Dep't of Safety*, 821 F. Supp. 3d 202, (D. N.H. Feb. 25, 2026), *Gordon-Darby Holdings v. NH Dep't of Safety*, 2026 U.S. Dist. LEXIS 95919 (Apr. 29, 2026), *Gordon-Darby Holdings v. Quinn*, 174 F.4th 255 (1st Cir. Apr. 30, 2026). Issues raised and facts alleged in the complaint which are pertinent herein are set forth below.

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This Court's familiarity with the background of this matter, and prior and related proceedings, is assumed. See Gordon-Darby Holdings, Inc. v. NH Dep't of Safety, 817 F. Supp. 3d 82, 90 (D. N.H. 2026), Gordon-Darby Holdings, Inc. v. NH Dep't of Safety, 821 F. Supp. 3d 202, (D. N.H. Feb. 25, 2026), Gordon-Darby Holdings v. NH Dep't of Safety, 2026 U.S. Dist. LEXIS 95919 (Apr. 29, 2026), Gordon-Darby Holdings v. Quinn, 174 F.4th 255 (1st Cir. Apr. 30, 2026). Issues raised and facts alleged in the complaint which are pertinent herein are set forth below.

As the complaint explains, the New Hampshire General Court enacted HB2, which repealed the statutory authority underlying the I/M program contained in New Hampshire's SIP (effective January 31, 2026) in June of 2025. ECF-1, ¶¶109-111. The complaint nevertheless alleges that the named defendants (collectively referenced therein as the "State Officials") "have violated and are in violation of" the CAA "by failing to implement" the I/M program as required by New Hampshire's SIP (*id.*, ¶2), which, in turn, constitutes a violation of an emission standard or limitation warranting civil penalties along with declaratory and injunctive relief. *Id.*, ¶4 (citing 42 U.S.C. §7604(f)(3)). Plaintiffs allege that "[t]his decision to cease complying with the I/M requirements of New Hampshire's federally approved SIP, prior to approval of a revised SIP by EPA, is in direct violation of the State's obligations under federal law." *Id.*, ¶134.

More specifically, according to the complaint, the "emission standards or limitations" (*id.*, ¶147 (citing 42 U.S.C. § 7604(a)(l) and (f))) that Plaintiffs allege are being violated require all of the named "State Officials" to:

1) "[R]etain the services of a 'supplier' as provided for in New Hampshire's SIP to serve as the contracted vendor" for the I/M program. *Id.*, ¶143 (citing N.H. Admin. Code Saf-C 3202.24, 3209.01(d), 3209.03(e), 3209.04(a), 3209.08(d), 3209.09(d));

2) "[I]ssue certificates of appointment to qualifying inspection stations. *Id.*, ¶144 (citing N.H. Admin. Code Saf-C 3205.01-3205.06);

3) "[I]ssue mechanic approval cards to qualifying mechanics. *Id.*, ¶145 (citing N.H. Admin. Code Saf-C 3205.10), and;

Admin. Code Saf-C 3202.24, 3209.0l(d), 3209.03(e), 3209.04(a), 3209.08(d),

4) "[P]rovide counter service for inspection sticker purchases and returns." *Id.*, ¶146, (citing N.H. Admin. Code Saf-C 3209.02(a). 3209.09(d)).

(b) "[I]ssue certificates of appointment to qualifying inspection stations. Id., ¶144

The complaint does not allege any other violation of an identified State law or rule. *See id.* at (citing N.H. Admin. Code Saf-C 3205.01-3205.06);

¶¶100, 103-106, 119 (alleging violation of regulatory requirements without citations).

(c) "[I]ssue mechanic approval cards to qualifying mechanics. Id., ¶145 (citing N.H.

Gordon-Darby is alleged to have "suffered harm from the State Officials' suspension of Admin. Code Saf-C 3205.10), and;

the I/M program and termination of Gordon-Darby NHOST's contract as the I/M program

(d) "[P]rovide counter service for inspection sticker purchases and returns." Id.,

vendor." ECF-1, ¶46. Plaintiffs contend that such harm would be redressed if "this Court were ¶146, (citing N.H. Admin. Code Saf-C 3209.02(a).

to order the State Officials to implement the I/M program as codified in New Hampshire's SIP"

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because "the State Officials would need to retain a new vendor to administer the I/M program" id. at ¶¶100, 103-106, 119 (alleging violation of regulatory requirements without citations).

(*id*., ¶47) and Gordon-Darby would "have the opportunity to bid for that new vendor contract."

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order the State Officials to implement the I/M program as codified in New Hampshire's SIP"

concentrations resulting from the State Officials' suspension of the I/M program." *Id.*, ¶33.

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(id., ¶47) and Gordon-Darby would "have the opportunity to bid for that new vendor contract."

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would be restored." *Id.*, ¶35. Ms. Jonas also alleges experiencing anxiety about the public safety

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Governor and Executive Council is required for "any contracts associated with implementing and

enforcing the I/M obligations set forth in the New Hampshire SIP." *Id.*, ¶¶52, 56. The complaint additionally alleges that each individual Executive Councilor has the same authority and responsibility. *Id.*, ¶¶57-61. The complaint makes no express allegation that the Governor and Council Defendants are responsible for implementing and enforcing any part of the I/M obligations set forth in the SIP.

STANDARD OF REVIEW

A rule 12(b)(1) facial challenge to a complaint based on standing requires a District Court to determine the legal sufficiency of the complaint as a matter of law (*Wilson v. HSBC Mortg. Servs., Inc.*, 744 F.3d 1, 8 (1st Cir. 2014)), taking all facts alleged as true. *Valentin v. Bella Vista*, 254 F.3d 358, 363 (1st Cir. 2001) (distinguishing facial and factual standing challenges). When evaluating a complaint under Rule 12(b)(1), courts "apply the same plausibility standard used to evaluate a motion under Rule 12(b)(6) . . ." *Webb v. Injured Workers Pharm., LLC*, 72 F.4th 365, 371 (1st Cir., 2023) (citations omitted).

When deciding whether a complaint can survive a Rule 12(b)(6) motion, District Courts accept all well-pleaded facts as true and indulge all reasonable inferences in favor of the plaintiff. *Lavigne v. Great Salt Bay Cmty. Sch. Bd.*, 146 F.4th 115, 123 (1st Cir. 2025) (citations omitted). Courts must also identify and disregard allegations which are legal conclusions or mere recitals of the elements of a cause of action. *Ocasio-Hernandez v. Fortuño-Burset*, 640 F.3d 1, 12 (1st Cir. 2011) (citations omitted). The question is whether the facts alleged "plausibly narrate a claim for relief." *Schatz v. Republican State Leadership Comm.*, 669 F.3d 50, 55 (1st Cir. 2012) (citations omitted).

risks from unsafe vehicles operating on New Hampshire's roads, which would also allegedly be reduced if the I/M program were to be resumed. Id. ¶¶40-41.

As to the respective responsibilities and authority of the Governor and Executive Council, the complaint alleges that both defendants possess and are charged with "authority and responsibility . . . over the administration of the affairs of the State" and also that approval of the Governor and Executive Council is required for "any contracts associated with implementing and enforcing the I/M obligations set forth in the New Hampshire SIP." Id., ¶¶52, 56. The complaint additionally alleges that each individual Executive Councilor has the same authority and responsibility. Id., ¶¶57-61. The complaint makes no express allegation that the Governor and Council Defendants are responsible for implementing and enforcing any part of the I/M obligations set forth in the SIP.

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ARGUMENT

I. The Claims Against the Governor and Council Defendants Should be Dismissed Pursuant to Rule 12(b)(1) Because Plaintiffs Do Not and Cannot Allege that Such Defendants Violated the Clean Air Act.

A. The Constitutional Minimum for Citizen Suit Standing

Federal District Courts are required to resolve a Rule 12(b)(1) challenge to their Article III subject matter jurisdiction before addressing the merits of a case. *Steel Co. v. Citizens for a Better Env't*, 523 U.S. 83, 93-102 (1998); *Seafreeze Shoreside v. United States DOI*, 123 F.4th 1, 15 (1st Cir. 2024); *McBreairty v. Miller*, 93 F.4th 513, 517 (1st Cir. 2024) (quoting *Steel Co.*, 523 U.S. at 95). If the plaintiff fails at the pleading stage to allege facts demonstrating each element of standing, "there is no case or controversy for the federal court to resolve." *Wiener v. MIB Grp., Inc.*, 86 F.4th 76, 84 (1st Cir. 2023) (quoting *TransUnion LLC v. Ramirez*, 594 U.S. 413, 423 (2021)).

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A. The Constitutional Minimum for Citizen Suit Standing

Article III, §2 of the United States Constitution limits federal court jurisdiction to cases and controversies where a plaintiff has standing to challenge the alleged misconduct of the defendant(s). *Lujan v. Defenders of Wildlife*, 504 U.S. 555, 560 (1992). This limitation is "fundamental to the judiciary's proper role in our system of government." *Dantzler, Inc. v. Empresas Berrios Inventory & Operations, Inc.*, 958 F.3d 38, 46 (1st Cir. 2020) (citations omitted).

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Standing requires a plaintiff to show that he or she has suffered, or imminently will suffer, (1) a concrete and particularized "injury in fact" (2) that is fairly traceable to the challenged action of the defendant, and which is (3) likely to be redressed by judicial relief. *Lujan*, 504 U.S. at 560–61. Demonstrating injury-in-fact, causation, and redressability is not a pleading requirement but is "an indispensable part of the plaintiff's case." *Dantzler*, 958 F.3d at

"fundamental to the judiciary's proper role in our system of government." Dantzler, Inc. v. Empresas Berrios Inventory & Operations, Inc., 958 F.3d 38, 46 (1st Cir. 2020) (citations omitted).

B. The Complaint Does Not Allege Any Injury-in-Fact to Any Legally Protected Interest of Either Plaintiff Connected to a Violation of An Emission Standard or SIP Requirement by the Governor and Council Defendants.

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B. The Complaint Does Not Allege Any Injury-in-Fact to Any Legally Protected Interest of Either Plaintiff Connected to a Violation of An Emission Standard or SIP Requirement by the Governor and Council Defendants.

1. *Neither Plaintiff Alleges Injuries Connected to Any Violation of an Emission Limitation or SIP Requirement by the Governor and Council Defendants.*

An "injury-in-fact," for standing purposes, requires "an invasion of a legally protected interest . . ." *Sea Shore Corp. v. Sullivan*, 158 F.3d 51, 55 (1st Cir. 1998). A CAA citizen suit plaintiff thus must claim an Article III injury "in connection with the alleged CAA violation." *Conservation Law Found., Inc. v. Acad. Express, LLC*, 129 F.4th 78, 83 (1st Cir. 2025). District courts cannot entertain CAA citizen suits which do not "involve the enforcement of standards set out" in the CAA or an approved SIP. *Conservation Law Found. v. Federal Highway Admin.*, 24 F.3d 1465, 1477 (1st Cir. 1994). But absent an Article III injury, a plaintiff cannot maintain a CAA citizen suit "even in the context of a statutory violation." *Conserv. Law Found*, 129 F.4th at 83 (citing *Spokeo, Inc. v. Robins*, 578 U.S. 330, 341 (2016)).

The "linchpin" of citizen suit jurisdiction is whether the plaintiff claims "violations of specific provisions of the act or specific provisions of an applicable implementation plan…" *Conservation Law Found. v. Busey*, 79 F.3d 1250, 1258 (1st Cir. 1996) (quoting *Wilder v. Thomas*, 854 F.2d 605, 613 (2d Cir. 1988)). Here, Plaintiffs do not (and cannot) allege any Article III injury to themselves which is connected to any alleged CAA violation by the Governor and Council Defendants. *See Conservation Law Found.*, 129 F.4th at 83. Plaintiffs thus fail to allege any cognizable injury-in-fact caused by these defendants as required for Article III standing. *See Lujan*, 504 U.S. at 560. Absent such allegations, the complaint must be dismissed. *See Bingham v. Massachusetts*, 616 F.3d 1, 5 (1st Cir. 2018).

The complaint alleges that the Governor and Council Defendants have authority over the administration of State affairs, including the approval of "any contracts associated with implementing and enforcing the I/M obligations set forth in the New Hampshire SIP," (ECF-1, ¶¶ 52, 56-61) and that the Governor and Council Defendants denied NHDOS's request to extend the termination date for Gordon-Darby NHOST's contract. ECF-1, ¶ 124. Yet, the complaint makes no allegation that the Governor and Council Defendants have any authority over, or took any action or omission in violation of, the CAA or the SIP. Indeed, the denial of NHDOS's request to extend the termination date for Gordon-Darby NHOST's contract was not a violation of any emission limit or SIP requirement, and the complaint does not assert otherwise. Rather, the denial was an exercise of the Governor and Executive Council's sovereign procurement power, and the CAA does not (and cannot) regulate sovereign State procurement actions taken under State law (RSA 4:15). *See* U.S. Const. amend. X (discussed below).

Thus, the complaint does not set forth any legally cognizable injury-in-fact to Plaintiffs caused by the Governor and Council Defendants because it lacks any allegations that those defendants violated an emission standard or limitation. The complaint as a result neither connects Plaintiffs' alleged injuries to any action or inaction of the Governor and Council Defendants nor alleges the redressability of such injuries and thus does not plausibly allege standing in any respect. *See Donahue v. City of Boston*, 304 F.3d 110, 118 (1st Cir. 2002).

ii. Plaintiffs' Claims Against State Defendants for their Action or Inaction in their Capacity as Regulators Are Not Legally Cognizable Citizen Suit Claims.

While not ascribing any SIP or NHDOS regulatory duties to the Governor and Council Defendants, the complaint nevertheless asserts that all defendants violated the CAA by failing to implement deauthorized and repealed NHDOS rules and thus attempts to treat the Governor and Council Defendants as regulators. ECF-1, ¶¶143-146. But, as the First Circuit Court of Appeals has recently reiterated, the "linchpin" of citizen suit jurisdiction is whether the plaintiff claims "violations of specific provisions of the act or specific provisions of an applicable implementation plan." *Conservation Law Found. v. Busey*, 79 F.3d 1250, 1258 (1st Cir. 1996) (quoting *Wilder v. Thomas*, 854 F.2d 605, 613 (2d Cir. 1988)). Here, Plaintiffs do not (and cannot) allege any Article III injury to themselves which is connected to any alleged CAA violation by the Governor and Council Defendants. *See Conservation Law Found.*, 129 F.4th at 83. Plaintiffs thus fail to allege any cognizable injury-in-fact caused by these defendants as required for Article III standing. *See Lujan*, 504 U.S. at 560. Absent such allegations, the complaint must be dismissed. *See Bingham v. Massachusetts*, 616 F.3d 1, 5 (1st Cir. 2010).

recently observed in direct response to the State's previous arguments to the contrary in *Gordon-Darby Holdings, Inc. v. Quinn*, "one circuit has held that 'the text and structure of the CAA make plain that [§7604(a)(1)] does not permit citizen suits against regulators *qua* regulators.' *Gordon-Darby*, 174 F.4th at 262 (quoting *Sierra Club v. Korleski*, 681 F.3d 342, 351 (6th Cir. 2012)) (emphasis original).

Korleski involved the State of Ohio's legislation allowing the Ohio EPA to issue permits to small stationary emitting sources without a determination that such sources will use best available control technologies, contrary to Ohio's SIP requirements. *Korleski*, 681 F.3d at 344. There, the Sixth Circuit observed that such a regulatory decision to cease enforcing the CAA amounts to a failure to implement or a "deficiency" rather than a "violation" of an emission standard or limitation under the CAA for which a CAA citizen suit may be brought. *Id.* at 344; 348-53. The Sixth Circuit reasoned that this interpretation better comports with the cooperative federalism principles underlying the CAA's detailed sanctions regime and sanctions clock enacted to "coax" states into compliance, and Supreme Court precedent interpreting nearly identical statutes. *Id.* at 349. Plaintiffs' claims against the State defendants (such as they are) in their regulatory capacity are likewise "profoundly contrary to the Act's remedial design." *Id.* at 352.[2]

HB2's repeal of authority to implement and enforce the I/M program is the linchpin of Plaintiffs' entire complaint. As discussed, every one of Plaintiffs' allegations that the State

[2] *Compare Am. Lung Ass'n v. EPA*, 985 F.3d 914, 931 (D.C. Cir. 2021) (citing 42 U.S.C. §7411(d)(2)(A) (permitting EPA to prescribe a SIP for a State); *see also* §7411(d)(2)(B) (EPA may enforce a State's SIP), §7413 (EPA may enforce against a State for failing to enforce its SIP); § 7410(k)(5), 7410(m) (EPA must provide schedule for State compliance pending the imposition of a federal "FIP") and §7509(a) and (b) (withholding of grants and imposition of sanctions for a State's failure to enforce its SIP).

Thus, the complaint does not set forth any legally cognizable injury-in-fact to Plaintiffs caused by the Governor and Council Defendants because it lacks any allegations that those defendants violated an emission standard or limitation. The complaint as a result neither connects Plaintiffs' alleged injuries to any action or inaction of the Governor and Council Defendants nor alleges the redressability of such injuries and thus does not plausibly allege standing in any respect. *See Donahue v. City of Boston*, 304 F.3d 110, 118 (1st Cir. 2002).

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348-53. The Sixth Circuit reasoned that this interpretation better comports with the cooperative federalism principles underlying the CAA's detailed sanctions regime and sanctions clock enacted to "coax" states into compliance, and Supreme Court precedent interpreting nearly identical statutes. Id. at 349. Plaintiffs' claims against the State defendants (such as they are) in their regulatory capacity are likewise "profoundly contrary to the Act's remedial design." Id. at 352. *See NRDC v. EPA*, 484 F.2d 1331, 1337 (1st Cir. 1973). Plaintiffs' claims are premised on HB2's repeal of the I/M program and not upon any alleged violation of any emissions standard or SIP requirement by the State defendants themselves as polluters and thus fail to allege injury in fact to any interest legally protected by the CAA. *See Conserv. Law Found. V. FHA*, 24 F.3d at 1477; *Conserv. Law Found. v. Acad. Express, LLC*, 129 F.4th at 83.

defendants violated the CAA by acting (or refusing to act) with respect to the I/M program is rooted in HB2's repeal of the State defendants' authority to implement the I/M program.

While *Korleski* addressed the State of Ohio's regulation of permitted stationary sources (smokestacks) rather than an I/M program, *Korleski* is also consistent with the principle that citizen suits only permit private parties to enforce pollution control standards against polluters. *See NRDC v. EPA*, 484 F.2d 1331, 1337 (1st Cir. 1973). Plaintiffs' claims are premised on HB2's repeal of authority to implement and enforce the I/M program is the linchpin of Plaintiffs' entire complaint. As discussed, every one of Plaintiffs' allegations that the State defendants violated the CAA by acting (or refusing to act) with respect to the I/M program is rooted in HB2's repeal of the State defendants' authority to implement the I/M program.

iii. *Gordon-Darby's Alleged Private Economic Injuries Are Likewise Not Legally Protected by the CAA.*

While Korleski addressed the State of Ohio's regulation of permitted stationary sources (smokestacks) rather than an I/M program, Korleski is also consistent with the principle that CAA citizen suits permit private parties to enforce pollution control standards as private citizen suits only permit private parties to enforce pollution control standards against polluters. attorneys general. *NRDC v. EPA*, 484 F.2d at 1337. When deciding the viability of a citizen See NRDC v. EPA, 484 F.2d 1331, 1337 (1st Cir. 1973). Plaintiffs' claims are premised on HB2's suit, this Court must strictly adhere to the statutory provisions conferring authority upon private repeal of the I/M program and not upon any alleged violation of any emissions standard or SIP citizens to enforce federal pollution control standards. *Garcia v. Cecos Int'l*, 761 F.2d 76, 81 requirement by the State defendants themselves as polluters and thus fail to allege injury in fact (1st Cir. 1985). Additional judicial remedies to redress private harm are not authorized by to any interest legally protected by the CAA. See Conserv. Law Found. V. FHA, 24 F.3d at 1477; citizen suits. *Middlesex Cty. Sewerage Ass'n v. Nat'l Sea Clammers Ass'n*, 453 U.S. 1, 14, 16– Conserv. Law Found. v. Acad. Express, LLC, 129 F.4th at 83.
18 (1981).

The complaint alleges Gordon-Darby "suffered harm" from the termination of its subsidiary's contract to perform outsourced work of State government as part of the former I/M program, and from the loss of an opportunity to bid on a potential future vendor contract. ECF-1, ¶¶ 46, 49. Yet, neither alleged injury is legally protected under the CAA, and thus cannot establish a cognizable "injury-in-fact" sufficient to establish Article III standing. *See Lujan*, 504

defendants violated the CAA by acting (or refusing to act) with respect to the I/M program is rooted in HB2's repeal of the State defendants' authority to implement the I/M program.

iii. Gordon-Darby's Alleged Private Economic Injuries Are Likewise Not Legally Protected by the CAA.

While *Korleski* addressed the State of Ohio's regulation of permitted stationary sources (smokestacks) rather than an I/M program, *Korleski* is also consistent with the principle that citizen suits only permit private parties to enforce pollution control standards against polluters. *See NRDC v. EPA*, 484 F.2d 1331, 1337 (1st Cir. 1973). Plaintiffs' claims are premised on HB2's repeal of the I/M program and not upon any alleged violation of any emissions standard or SIP requirement by the State defendants themselves as polluters and thus fail to allege injury in fact to any interest legally protected by the CAA. *See Conserv. Law Found. V. FHA*, 24 F.3d at 1477; *Conserv. Law Found. v. Acad. Express, LLC*, 129 F.4th at 83.

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First, neither the CAA nor the SIP guarantees a contractual right for Gordon-Darby NHOST to be retained to perform services in connection with an I/M program. The SIP contains no requirement for an I/M vendor, let alone a requirement to retain Gordon-Darby NHOST. While Gordon-Darby cites to now unauthorized and unenforceable NHDOS rules that reference a "supplier," defined as "the contracted vendor for the department's automated safety and emissions inspection program," (ECF-1, ¶143 (citing N.H. Admin Code Saf-C 3202.24, 3209.01(d), 3209.03(e), 3209.04(a), 3209.08(d), and 3209.09(d)), none of these rules require (or

ever required) NHDOS to retain a third-party vendor, let alone to retain Gordon-Darby NHOST. Indeed, N.H. Admin. Code Saf-C 3202.24 is simply a definition, and the other cited former rules merely relate to ministerial matters regarding inspection stickers. Id. In the absence of a requirement to retain a vendor, there cannot be any legally protected interest in the opportunity to bid on a vendor contract.

Second, Gordon-Darby NHOST's contract with the State was expressly terminable for convenience. See ECF-1 at PDF p. 53. Having bargained away any right to oppose termination of the contract after 30 days written notice (id.), Gordon-Darby NHOST cannot now assert an injury from NHDOS's exercise of its termination rights. As such, Gordon-Darby has no legally protected interest in continued or future contractual rights under the contract, the SIP or the CAA.

Third, Gordon Darby is a corporation which does not (and cannot) base its standing on a legally cognizable right to compliance with National Ambient Air Quality Standards (NAAQS). See Conservation Law Found., 129 F.4th at 88. Gordon Darby's alleged commercial harm (if harm it is, since the contract was terminable for convenience) is purely private. Congress did not authorize additional judicial remedies for private harm when it authorized citizen suits. See Clammers Ass'n, 453 U.S. at 14, 16–18; Gordon Darby's purely private (and bargained for) commercial harm is not legally cognizable injury in fact for the purposes of a CAA citizen suit. See Lujan, 504 U.S. at 560.

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iv. Ms. Jonas' Alleged Safety-Related Injuries are Also Not Injuries to Interests Legally Protected Under the CAA.

Among other alleged injuries, Ms. Jonas alleges she will be injured by the termination of the safety inspection portion of the former I/M program. ECF-1, ¶¶38-41. However, vehicle safety inspections (separate from emissions inspections) are not required or regulated under the CAA, are categorically not connected to any violation of the CAA, and were never incorporated into the SIP. The complaint does not allege otherwise. Accordingly, these alleged injuries do not establish a cognizable "injury-in-fact" in a CAA citizen suit.

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C. Plaintiffs Do Not Allege Any Injury Fairly Traceable to a Violation of the CAA or Any SIP Requirement by the Governor and Council Defendants.

The "traceability" component of standing requires a sufficiently direct causal connection between the challenged action and identified harm which must not be overly attenuated. *Katz v. Pershing, LLC*, 672 F.3d 64, 71 (1st Cir. 2012). "Traceability" therefore requires that the injury is (or will be) suffered "as a consequence" of the defendants' alleged unlawful conduct. *Johnson v. United States OPM*, 783 F.3d 655, 660-61 (1st Cir. 2015) (quoting *Valley Forge Christian College v. Americans United for Separation of Church & State,* 454 U.S. 464, 485 (1982)). The complaint, as noted, contains no such allegations with respect to the Governor and Council Defendants. The complaint instead insufficiently alleges injuries resulting from the "independent action of some other party not before the court" resulting from the General Court's

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While Plaintiffs broadly allege that all State defendants have violated the CAA by not implementing certain requirements of now unauthorized and unenforceable NHDOS rules incorporated into the SIP (ECF-1, ¶¶142-46), Plaintiffs nowhere allege that the Governor and Council Defendants had any responsibility or authority to implement the I/M program or the cited NHDOS rules. This omission reflects the reality that the Governor and Council Defendants have no such role or authority.

Indeed, Plaintiffs' alleged harm emanates from the repeal of the State laws authorizing the I/M program and not from the violation of any emission standard or SIP requirement by the

iv. Ms. Jonas' Alleged Safety-Related Injuries are Also Not Injuries to Interests Legally Protected Under the CAA.

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course prohibited by the Eleventh Amendment. *Town of Barnstable*, 786 F.3d at 138. (quoting *Mills v. Maine*, 118 F.3d 37, 55 (1st Cir. 1997) (other internal citations omitted)). Rather, to fit under the *Ex parte Young* exception and avoid an Eleventh Amendment bar to suit, the Court "need only conduct a straightforward inquiry into whether [the] complaint alleges an ongoing violation of federal law and *seeks relief properly characterized as prospective*." *Id.* at 139 (emphasis added) (internal citations omitted). However, "[r]elief that is 'tantamount to an award of damages for a past violation of federal law, even though styled as something else,' is barred." *Whalen v. Mass. Trial Court*, 397 F.3d 19, 29 (1st Cir. 2005) (quoting *Papasan v. Allain*, 478 U.S. 265, 278 (1986)). "Remedies designed to end a continuing violation of federal law are necessary to vindicate the federal interest in assuring the supremacy of that law." But compensatory or deterrence interests are insufficient to overcome the dictates of the Eleventh Amendment." *Papasan*, 478 U.S. at 278 (quoting *Green v. Mansour*, 474 U.S. 64, 68 (1985)).

Plaintiffs' request for civil penalties for pre-judgment past violations of the CAA do not constitute a remedy designed to stop an ongoing violation of federal law but would serve only to punish and deter future violations. *See Green*, 474 U.S. at 68. Such penalties for pre-judgment past violations cannot be properly characterized as prospective. Courts interpreting the identical Clean Water Act's and other environmental statutes' citizen suit provisions have consistently held that civil penalties do not qualify for the *Ex parte Young* exception. *See Conservation Law Found., Inc. v. Pease Dev. Auth.*, 2017 U.S. Dist. LEXIS 157191, at *21 (N.H. Dist. Ct. 2017) (dismissing plaintiff's claims for civil penalties under the Clean Water Act as barred retrospective relief under the Eleventh Amendment); *Murtaugh v. New York*, 810 F. Supp. 2d 446, 470 (N.D.N.Y. 2011) (same); *Nat. Res. Def. Council v. Cal. Dep't of Transp.*, 96 F.3d 420, 423 (9th Cir. 1996) (holding the Eleventh Amendment barred action against state officer for civil penalties and declaratory judgment based on the state's violation of the Clean Water Act). The civil penalties sought by Plaintiffs are thus barred by the Eleventh Amendment and should be dismissed.

Similarly, Plaintiffs' request for a declaratory judgment that Defendants "have violated . . . 'emission standards or limitations' within the meaning of 42 U.S.C. § 7604(a)(1) and (f)" serves no prospective relief purpose nor does such a declaratory judgment result in an end to any ongoing violation of federal law as required by the limitation exceptions of the *Ex parte Young* doctrine. ECF 1, at Prayer (1). Thus, Plaintiffs' request for retrospective declaratory relief must also be dismissed as prohibited by the Eleventh Amendment. See Green, 474 U.S. at 73-74;

penalties and declaratory judgment based on the state's violation of the Clean Water Act). The civil penalties sought by Plaintiffs are thus barred by the Eleventh Amendment and should be dismissed.

Similarly, Plaintiffs' request for a declaratory judgment that Defendants "have violated…emission standards or limitations' within the meaning of 42 U.S.C. § 7604(a)(1) and (f)" serves no prospective relief purpose nor does such a declaratory judgment result in an end to any ongoing violation of federal law as required by the limitation exceptions of the *Ex parte Young* doctrine. ECF-1, at Prayer (1). Thus, Plaintiffs' request for retrospective declaratory relief must also be dismissed as prohibited by the Eleventh Amendment. *See Green*, 474 U.S. at 73-74; *Murtaugh*, 810 F. Supp. 2d at 470 ("The doctrine of *Ex parte Young* 'applies only to prospective relief, does not permit judgments against state officers declaring that they violated federal law in the past…and has no application in suits against the States and their agencies, which are barred regardless of the relief sought'" (quoting *Puerto Rico Aqueduct and Sewer Auth. v. Metcalf & Eddy, Inc.*, 506 U.S. 139, 146 (1993)).

III. The Complaint Should be Dismissed Pursuant to Rule 12(b)(6) Because it Fails to State a CAA Citizen Suit Claim Against the Governor and Council Defendants.

As discussed, the "linchpin" of this Court's jurisdiction under 42 U.S.C. 7604 is whether the complaint alleges "violations of specific provisions of the act or specific provisions of an applicable implementation plan…". *Conserv. Law Found. v. Busey*, 79 F.3d at 1258. That linchpin, also essential for Plaintiffs' standing, is conspicuously absent from the complaint with respect to the Governor and Council Defendants, as previously discussed herein. In particular, the absence of any allegations that the Governor and Council Defendants themselves (as opposed to the broader catchall of "State Officials") engaged in any conduct in violation of any emission standards or limitations or failed to perform any duties mandated by the CAA is fatal to Plaintiffs' attempt to assert a permissible citizen suit claim under the CAA. See Section I.B.ii, supra (citing Korleski,

681 F.3d at 344; 348-53). Accordingly, the complaint fails to state claims upon which relief can be granted under the CAA and the claims against the Governor and Council Defendants should be dismissed.

limitation or requirement of the SIP mandates dismissal of the Governor and Council Defendants for failure to state a claim.

Simply put, the Governor and Council Defendants do not implement or enforce the I/M program, do not implement or enforce NHDOS administrative rules, and are not alleged to have engaged in any unlawful act under the SIP, the CAA, or any law. Accordingly, there is no plausibly alleged basis for their continued retention as Defendants in this case and the claims against them should be dismissed as a result. Moreover, as set forth above, to the extent Plaintiffs raise claims against the Governor and Council Defendants as "regulators *qua* regulators" fails to assert a permissible citizen suit claim under the CAA. *See* Section I.B.ii, *supra* (citing *Korleski*, 681 F.3d at 344; 348-53). Accordingly, the complaint fails to state claims upon which relief can be granted under the CAA and the claims against the Governor and Council Defendants should be dismissed.

CONCLUSION

In the absence of any allegation of a violation of any specific emission standard or limitation or any specific provisions of the SIP, every successive domino in the Plaintiffs case against the Governor and Council Defendants falls in a circular pattern, from injury in fact, traceability, and redressability, to the failure to state a claim under the CAA, to the final constitutional dominos. The Tenth Amendment prohibits the federal government from compelling State officials to administer a federal regulatory program. The Eleventh Amendment limits this Court to the provision of prospective relief against State officials which both prohibits such officials from enforcing state law in a way that violates federal law and directly serves to bring an end to the violation(s). For the reasons set forth herein, the Governor and Council Defendants respectfully request that this Court dismiss Plaintiffs' claims against them and grant to them such other and further relief as to the Court may seem just, proper and equitable.

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Respectfully submitted,

KELLY AYOTTE, in her capacity as the Governor of the State of New Hampshire,
THE EXECUTIVE COUNCIL OF THE STATE OF NEW HAMPSHIRE, and its respective members in their official capacities,
DISTRICT 1 EXECUTIVE COUNCILOR JOSEPH D. KENNEY,
DISTRICT 2 EXECUTIVE COUNCILOR KAREN LIOT HILL,
DISTRICT 3 EXECUTIVE COUNCILOR JANET STEVENS,
DISTRICT 4 EXECUTIVE COUNCILOR JOHN STEPHEN,
DISTRICT 5 EXECUTIVE COUNCILOR DAVID K. WHEELER,

By and through their counsel

JOHN M. FORMELLA
ATTORNEY GENERAL

September 21, 2026

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JOHN M. FORMELLA
ATTORNEY GENERAL
September 21, 2026

/s/ Mark L. Lucas

Mark L. Lucas, Bar #274692
Assistant Attorney General
Joshua C. Harrison, Bar #269564
Senior Assistant Attorney General
Environmental Protection Bureau
Office of the Attorney General
New Hampshire Department of Justice
1 Granite Place South
Concord, New Hampshire 03301
(603) 271-3679
Mark.L.Lucas@doj.nh.gov
Joshua.C.Harrison@doj.nh.gov

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CERTIFICATE OF SERVICE

I hereby certify that a copy of the foregoing was served via the Court's ECF filing system on all counsel of record.

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